SOCIOECONOMIC FALSE BELIEF #24 · WORK AND IDENTITY

“My value depends on how much I earn.”

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Where it often comes from

When salary becomes the scoreboard, a raise feels like approval and a pay cut feels like a demotion of the self. This can come from families who compared incomes, workplaces that publicly ranked pay, or a culture that treats earnings as a measure of success. It can also arise from real need: when money is tight, earning more can feel like the only path to safety, and we slip from “I need more” to “I am worth more.”

What Scripture teaches

Scripture says that we were redeemed not with perishable things such as silver or gold, but with the precious blood of Christ. The price of our worth has already been paid in the highest currency there is. The psalmist marvels that God is mindful of us and cares for us. We are told that we are worth more than many sparrows. A paycheck pays for work. It does not tell us who we are.

> *“For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life you inherited from your forefathers, but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot”* (1 Peter 1:18–19).

Also see

> “What is man that You are mindful of him, or the son of man that You care for him?” (Psalm 8:4).

> “And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows” (Luke 12:7).

> “Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life” (Isaiah 43:4).

> “But God proves His love for us in this: While we were still sinners, Christ died for us” (Romans 5:8).

Common self-statements

- The more I earn, the more I matter.
- If someone earns more than me, they are worth more.
- My salary is my report card.
- I have to keep climbing to be worth anything.
- Making less means being less.
- People respect me for my income.

Common logical errors

- Social comparison: Measuring my value against other people’s pay.
- Labeling: Treating a number as my identity.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that I am either a high earner and successful or low and a failure.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling small when the number is small and concluding that I am small.

Challenging questions

- What would I say to a friend who believed this?
- What did God pay for me, and what does that say about my value?
- Whose pay do I compare mine to, and why?
- What do I need to earn for security, and what part is about status?
- What things do I contribute that no salary measures?
- What would change if my worth were already settled?

Truth summary

> My salary measures the market's price for a task, not God's price for me. I was redeemed with the precious blood of Christ. I can pursue fair pay and wise provision without making the number my worth.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money
- Worldly
- Riches, Beware of
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Money/Riches

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Is He Worthy — Andrew Peterson
Honest recognition of a broken world can lead to hope in Christ's final restoration.

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

All Things New — Steven Curtis Chapman
God's renewing work offers hope beyond failure, decay, and loss.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My value depends on how much I earn"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My value depends on how much I earn." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose income do I compare mine to?
- ☐ What do I need versus what do I want for status?
- ☐ What did Christ pay for me?
- ☐ What do I give that is not paid?
- ☐ What would change if my worth were settled?
- ☐ What would I say to a friend?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My worth was paid for by Christ.
- ☐ My salary is not my value.
- ☐ I can seek fair pay without needing it for identity.
- ☐ Comparison steals contentment.
- ☐ I contribute in ways no paycheck measures.
- ☐ I am loved at every income level.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Peter 1:18–19
  "For you know that it was not with perishable things such as silver or gold that you were redeemed from the empty way of life you inherited from your forefathers, but with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot."
- ☐ Luke 12:7
  "And even the very hairs of your head are all numbered. So do not be afraid; you are worth more than many sparrows."
- ☐ Isaiah 43:4
  "Because you are precious and honored in My sight, and because I love you, I will give men in exchange for you and nations in place of your life."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Number and worth: Each week, write your biggest money thought and a sentence that separates the number from your worth.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Peter 1:18–19 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Christ paid for me, so my worth is not set by my salary.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

This card is educational and is not financial or legal advice. Choose steps you can do safely. If you are without food, housing, or safety, contact your church, a trusted advisor, or local assistance services.

- ☐ Write two columns. On one side list what you need to earn for security. On the other list what you feel you need for status.
- ☐ Limit comparisons. Avoid checking what others earn this week and notice how you feel.
- ☐ Name your contributions. List five things you give that no one pays you for.
- ☐ Memorize 1 Peter 1:18–19. Read it aloud each morning.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My value depends on how much I earn": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Worth, not salary
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My value depends on how much I earn.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, You paid a price for me that no salary could match. Free me from measuring myself by income. Help me work well, provide wisely, and rest in the value You have given me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.